

[Return to Search](#)

Skullcaps and turbans

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C. The congregation: its whole and its parts .

Especially in the hot summer time, this late afternoon lull in activity is the pleasantest time of day, during which the men of the village rest up from their labors and spend a while together in conversation before dinner. The disposition of persons during this period replicates the power structure of the village as a whole. The old men, the ifqiren, have been in possession of the center of sanctity -- the mosque -- for the better part of the afternoon, and they are joined by slightly younger men (in their 50's and 60's) on the terrace of the mosque, overlooking the village plaza (asays). They sit on the terrace, on their haunches, their arms wrapped around their legs, commenting on the affairs of the day.

[571](#)
[Social Relationships](#)
[And Groups](#)

[887](#)
[Activities Of The Aged](#)

Below them, standing in the plaza, is another "j_ema't", this one composed of the "skullcaps", the younger married men of the village, who are also members of the congregation but who do not habitually spend time in the mosque precincts. The conversation in this group is on the whole freer and considerably more irreverent than in the "turbans" group. Like the old men, they too comment on politics and personalities of the day, but their talk is interspersed with more joking and occasional obscenity. Inevitably, the conversation returns to the great preoccupations of their age-group: possibilities of finding jobs. Cases of their acquaintances who have gotten jobs are minutely dissected and analysed, [■ 215](#) and even the merest rumor of a job possibility will provide weeks' worth of speculation. They speak also of famous [unknown]Sluh[unknown] singers and recording artists they have heard on the radio or whose records they may own.

[521](#)
[Conversation](#)

[571](#)
[Social Relationships](#)
[And Groups](#)

[794](#)
[Congregations](#)

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